Then from under his saddle Afzal brought out his gun and fired
The shot entered the body of *Daaktar*

It passed through his chest and out his back
His body was rent, and his soul fled out

The British began to retreat, ‘The brave ones of Kabul on their tail’.

Then Burnes, of swift decision, ordered them
To bring artillery to the fight
It roared and rumbled like the sky
The sound of it shook the world

At this, the hearts of the believers were astonished
The world had been darkened

They saw that there was nothing they could do
How can one drop of water conquer a river in spate?

So too went Afzal and the Amir
They hurried from the battlefield to the high mountains

There they chose a place to camp
And rested awhile from their trials, and their rage.[98]

Two days later, on the evening of 4 November, a very anxious Macnaghten was taking his evening ride on the outskirts of Kabul in the company of his Military Secretary, George Lawrence, and a small escort of cavalry. The news of the death of Dr Lord and several other officers had arrived the day before, and had been followed that afternoon by an apocalyptic despatch from Burnes, urging that the British abandon all their positions north of Kabul and concentrate their troops in the capital. The day had been spent in nervous discussion – should the troops be pulled in? Should a second force be gathered and sent north? Was it wise to drain Kabul of yet more troops? ‘Just as we were approaching the Residency,’ remembered Lawrence, ‘we were surprised by a horseman suddenly riding up, who, pushing his horse between the Envoy and myself, asked me “if that was the Lord Sahib”.’

On my saying yes, he caught hold of Sir William’s bridle, exclaiming ‘the Ameer, the Ameer!’ The Envoy, surprised and agitated, called out, ‘Who, who? Where, where?’ Looking behind me on the instant, I saw another horseman close to us, who riding up, threw himself off his horse,